The Two Noble Kinsmen

By William Shakespeare

Directed by Abigail Olshin

HST Shakespeare Troupe 2025-2026

The Two Noble Kinsmen
By William Shakespeare
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with Michael Poston and Rebecca Niles
Adapted by Abigail Olshin
Folger Shakespeare Library

Characters in the Play

The two noble kinsmen, cousins, nephews of Creon, King of Thebes:
ARCITE
PALAMON

THESEUS, Duke of Athens
HIPPOLYTA, Queen of the Amazons, later Duchess of Athens
EMILIA, her sister
PIRITHOUS, friend to Theseus

Three QUEENS, widows of the kings killed in laying siege to Thebes

The JAILER of Theseus's prison
The Jailer's DAUGHTER
The Jailer's BROTHER
The WOOER of the Jailer's daughter
A DOCTOR

ARTESIUS, an Athenian soldier
VALERIUS, a Theban
WOMAN, attending on Emilia
An Athenian GENTLEMAN

A SCHOOLMASTER

ACT 1

Scene 1

Music. Enter Theseus between
Then Hippolyta, the bride, led by Pirithous.
After her, Emilia, holding
up her train. Then Attendants.

The Song, sung by the Boy.

Enter three Queens in black. The first Queen falls down at the foot
of Theseus; the second falls down at the foot of
Hippolyta; the third before Emilia.

FIRST QUEEN
O, Thesus;
For pity's sake and true gentility's,
Hear and respect me.

SECOND QUEEN
For your mother's sake,
Hear and respect me. 5

THIRD QUEEN
Be advocate
For us and our distresses.

THESEUS Sad lady, rise.

HIPPOLYTA Stand up.

EMILIA
No knees to me. 10
What woman I may stead that is distressed
Does bind me to her.

THESEUS
What's your request? Deliver you for all.

FIRST QUEEN
We are three queens whose sovereigns fell before
The wrath of cruel Creon, in the foul fields of Thebes. 15
He will not suffer us to burn their bones,
To urn their ashes, nor to take th' offense
Of mortal loathsomeness from the blest eye
Of holy Phoebus, but infects the winds

With stench of our slain lords. O, pity, duke! 20
Thou purger of the Earth, draw thy feared sword
That does good turns to th' world; give us the bones
Of our dead kings, that we may chapel them.

THESEUS Pray you, kneel not.
I was transported with your speech and suffered 25
Your knees to wrong themselves. I have heard the fortunes
Of your dead lords, which gives me such lamenting
As wakes my vengeance and revenge for 'em.
O, no knees, none, widow!
Unto the helmeted Bellona[1] use them 30
And pray for me, your soldier.
Troubled I am.

The First Queen rises.

SECOND QUEEN Honored Hippolyta,
Most dreaded Amazonian,
Speak 't in a woman's key, like such a woman 35
As any of us three; weep ere you fail.
Lend us a knee.

HIPPOLYTA Poor lady, say no more.
I had as lief trace this good action with you
As that whereto I am going, and never yet 40
Went I so willing way. My lord is taken
Heart-deep with your distress; let him consider.
I'll speak anon. *Second Queen rises.*

THIRD QUEEN O, my petition was
Set down in ice, which by hot grief uncandied 45
Melts into drops

EMILIA Pray stand up.
Your grief is written in your cheek.

THIRD QUEEN . *She rises.*
Lady, lady, alack!
He that will all the treasure know o' th' Earth 50
Must know the center too; O, pardon me!
Extremity, that sharpens sundry wits,
Makes me a fool.

[1] The Roman Goddess of war

EMILIA
Your sorrow beats so ardently upon me
That it shall make a counter-reflect ’gainst 55
My brother’s heart and warm it to some pity,
Though it were made of stone. Pray have good
comfort.

THESEUS, *coming forward*
Forward to th’ temple. Leave not out a jot
O’ th’ sacred ceremony. 60

FIRST QUEEN O, this celebration
Will longer last and be more costly than
Your suppliants’ war. Think, dear duke, think
What beds our slain kings have!

SECOND QUEEN What griefs our beds, 65
That our dear lords have none!

THIRD QUEEN None fit for th’ dead.

FIRST QUEEN But our lords
Lie blist’ring ’fore the visitating sun,
And were good kings when living. 70

THESEUS
It is true, and I will give you comfort
To give your dead lords graves;
The which to do must make some work with Creon.

FIRST QUEEN
And that work presents itself to th’ doing.
Now ’twill take form; Now he’s secure, 75
Not dreams we stand before your puissance,
Rinsing our holy begging in our eyes
To make petition clear.

SECOND QUEEN Now you may take him,
Drunk with his victory. 80

THIRD QUEEN And his army full
Of bread and sloth.

THESEUS Artesius, forth and levy
Our worthiest instruments, whilst we dispatch

This grand act of our life. 85

FIRST QUEEN, *to Second and Third Queens*
Dowagers, take hands.
Let us be widows to our woes.

ALL THE QUEENS Farewell.

SECOND QUEEN
We come unseasonably; but when could grief
Cull forth, as unpanged judgment can, fitt'st time 90
For best solicitation?

THESEUS Why, good ladies,
This is a service whereto I am going
Greater than any was.

FIRST QUEEN The more proclaiming 95
Our suit shall be neglected when her arms,
Able to lock Jove from a synod[2], shall
By warranting moonlight corselet thee. O, when
Her twinning cherries shall their sweetness fall
Upon thy tasteful lips, what wilt thou think 100
Of rotten kings or blubbered queens?

HIPPOLYTA, *to Theseus* Though much unlike
You should be so transported, yet I think
Did I not, by th' abstaining of my joy—
Which breeds a deeper longing—cure their surfeit 105
That craves a present med'cine, I should pluck
All ladies' scandal on me. *She kneels.*
Prorogue this business we are going about, and hang
Your shield afore your heart.

ALL QUEENS, *to Emilia* O, help now! 110
Our cause cries for your knee.

EMILIA, *to Theseus, kneeling* If you grant not
My sister her petition, I'll not dare
To ask you anything, nor be so hardy
Ever to take a husband. 115

THESEUS Pray stand up.
Hippolyta and Emilia rise.
I am entreating of myself to do

[2] A gathering of the gods

That which you kneel to have me.—Pirithous,
Lead on the bride; get you and pray the gods
For success and return; omit not anything 120
In the pretended celebration.—Queens,
Follow your soldier. *To Artesius.* As before, hence you,
And at the banks of Aulis meet us with
The forces you can raise. *Artesius exits.*
To Hippolyta
—Set you forward, 125
For I will see you gone.

The wedding procession begins to exit towards the temple.

—Pirithous,
Keep the feast full; bate not an hour on ’t.

PIRITHOUS Sir,
I’ll follow you at heels. 130

THESEUS Cousin, I charge you,
Budge not from Athens.
—Once more, farewell all.

All but Theseus and the Queens exit.

FIRST QUEEN
Thus dost thou still make good the tongue o’ th’world.

SECOND QUEEN
And earn’st a deity equal with Mars. 135

THIRD QUEEN If not above him, for
Thou, being but mortal, makest affections bend
To godlike honors; they themselves, some say,
Groan under such a mast’ry.

THESEUS Good cheer, ladies. 140
Now turn we towards your comforts.

Flourish. They exit.

Scene 2

Enter Palamon and Arcite.

ARCITE
Dear Palamon, dearer in love than blood
And our prime cousin, let us leave the city
Thebes, and the temptings in ’t, before we further
Sully our gloss of youth.

PALAMON Your advice
Is cried up with example. What strange ruins,
Since first we went to school, may we perceive
Walking in Thebes!

ARCITE
How dangerous, if we will keep our honors,
Thebes is for our residing, where every evil
Hath a good color; where every seeming good's
A certain evil.

PALAMON 'Tis in our power—
Unless we fear that apes can tutor 's—to
Be masters of our manners. What need I
Affect another's gait? Or to be fond upon
Another's way of speech, when by mine own
I may be reasonably conceived—saved too,
Speaking it truly? Why am I bound
By any generous bond to follow him
Follows his tailor. What canon is there
That does command my rapier from my hip
To dangle 't in my hand. These poor slight sores
Need not a plantain. That which rips my bosom
Almost to th' heart's—

ARCITE Our Uncle Creon.

PALAMON He.
A most unbounded tyrant, whose successes
Makes heaven unfeared and villainy assured
Beyond its power there's nothing. Let
The blood of mine that's sib[3] to him be sucked
From me with leeches; let them break and fall
Off me with that corruption.

ARCITE Clear-spirited cousin,
Let's leave his court, that we may nothing share
Of his loud infamy.

PALAMON I think the echoes of his shames have deafed
The ears of heav'nly justice. *Enter Valerius.*

Valerius.

[3] Kin, related

VALERIUS
The King calls for you; yet be leaden-footed
Till his great rage be off him

PALAMON What's the matter?

VALERIUS
Theseus, who where he threats appalls, hath sent
Deadly defiance to him and pronounces
Ruin to Thebes.

ARCITE Let him approach. Yet what man
Thirds his own worth—the case is each of ours—
When that his action's dregged with mind assured
'Tis bad he goes about?

PALAMON Leave that unreasoned.
Our services stand now for Thebes, not Creon.
Yet to be neutral to him were dishonor,
Rebellious to oppose. Therefore we must
With him stand to the mercy of our fate.

ARCITE So we must.
To Valerius. Is 't said this war's afoot? Or, it shall be,
On fail of some condition?

VALERIUS 'Tis in motion;
The intelligence of state came in the instant
With the defier.

PALAMON Let's to the King. But alas,
Our hands advanced before our hearts, what will
The fall o' th' stroke do damage?

ARCITE Let th' event,
That never-erring arbitrator, tell us
When we know all ourselves, and let us follow
The becking of our chance.

They exit.

Scene 3

Enter Pirithous, Hippolyta, Emilia.

PIRITHOUS
No further.

HIPPOLYTA Sir, farewell. Repeat my wishes
To our great lord. Speed to him.

PIRITHOUS Though I know
His ocean needs not my poor drops, yet they
Must yield their tribute there.—My precious maid,
Those best affections that the heavens infuse
In their best-tempered pieces keep enthroned
In your dear heart!

EMILIA Thanks, sir. Remember me
To our all-royal brother, for whose speed
The great Bellona[4] I'll solicit; I'll offer to her
What I shall be advised she likes. Our hearts
Are in his army, in his tent.

HIPPOLYTA In 's bosom.
We have been soldiers, and we cannot weep
When our friends don their helms or put to sea.

PIRITHOUS Peace be to you

Pirithous exits.

EMILIA How his longing
Follows his friend!
Have you observed him
Since our great lord departed?

HIPPOLYTA With much labor,
And I did love him for 't. They two have cabined
In many as dangerous as poor a corner,
Peril and want contending; and they have
Fought out together where Death's self was lodged.
Yet fate hath brought them off. Their knot of love,
Tied, weaved, entangled, with so true, so long,
And with a finger of so deep a cunning,
May be outworn, never undone. I think
Theseus cannot be umpire to himself,
Cleaving his conscience into twain and doing
Each side like justice, which he loves best.

EMILIA Doubtless
There is a best, and reason has no manners
To say it is not you. I was acquainted
Once with a time when I enjoyed a playfellow;

[4] The Roman Goddess of war

You were at wars when she the grave enriched,
Who made too proud the bed; took leave o' th' moon, 40
Which then looked pale at parting, when our count
Was each eleven.

HIPPOLYTA 'Twas Flavina.

EMILIA Yes.
You talk of Pirithous' and Theseus' love. 45
Theirs has more ground, is more maturely seasoned,
More buckled with strong judgment. But I,
And she I sigh and spoke of, were things innocent,
Loved for we did, and like the elements
That know not what nor why, yet do effect 50
Rare issues by their operance, our souls
Did so to one another. Had mine ear
Stol'n some new air, or at adventure hummed one
From musical coinage, why, it was a note
Whereon her spirits would sojourn[5]—rather, dwell on— 55
And sing it in her slumbers. This rehearsal—
Which fury-innocent wots well comes in
Like old importment's bastard—has this end,
That the true love 'tween myself and other
More than in sex individual. 60

HIPPOLYTA You're out of breath,
And this high-speeded pace is but to say
That you shall never love any.

EMILIA I am sure I shall not. 65

HIPPOLYTA
But sure, my sister,
If I were ripe for your persuasion, you
Have said enough to shake me from the arm
Of the all-noble Theseus, for whose fortunes
I will now in and kneel, with great assurance 70
That we, more than his Pirithous, possess
The high throne in his heart.

EMILIA I am not
Against your faith, yet I continue mine.

They exit

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[5] A temporary stay. Here is means the contrast between sojourning with the tune (visiting it) and dwelling there (living permanently with it).

Scene 4

Cornets. A battle struck within; then a retreat.
Flourish.
Then enter, through one door,
Theseus, the victor.
Entering through another door, the three Queens
meet him, and fall on their faces before him.

FIRST QUEEN
To thee no star be dark!

SECOND QUEEN Both heaven and Earth
Friend thee forever.

THIRD QUEEN All the good that may
Be wished upon thy head, I cry "Amen" to 't!

THESEUS
Go and find out
The bones of your dead lords and honor them
With treble ceremony; So, adieu,
And heaven's good eyes look on you. *Queens exit.*
Enter Artesius and Soldiers bearing Palamon
and Arcite on biers.
What are those?

ARTESIUS
Men of great quality, as may be judged
By their appointment. They are nephews to the King.

THESEUS
By th' helm of Mars, I saw them in the war,
Like to a pair of lions. What prisoner was 't that told me
When I enquired their names?

ARTESIUS Wi' leave, they're called
Arcite and Palamon.

THESEUS 'Tis right; those, those.
They are not dead?

ARTESIUS
Yet they breathe
And have the name of men.

THESEUS Then like men use 'em.

Their lives concern us
Much more than Thebes is worth. We'd rather than have 'em
Prisoners to us than Death. For our love 25
And great Apollo's[6] mercy, all our best
Their best skill tender.—Lead into the city.

Flourish. They exit.

Scene 5

Music. Enter the Queens with the hearses of their knights, in a funeral solemnity

The dirge.

They exit severally.

[6] Greek god of archery, music and dance, truth and prophecy, healing and diseases, the Sun and light, poetry, and more.

ACT 2

Scene 1

Enter Jailer and Wooer.

JAILER I may depart with little while I live; something I
may cast to you, not much. Alas, the prison I keep,
though it be for great ones, yet they seldom come.
Marry, what I have, be it what it will, I will assure upon my
daughter at the day of my death. 5

WOOER Sir, I demand no more than your own offer,
and I will estate your daughter in what I have
promised.

JAILER But have you a full promise of her?
When that shall be seen, I tender my consent. 10

Enter the Jailer's Daughter.

WOOER I have sir. Here she comes.

JAILER*, to Daughter* Your friend and I have chanced
to name you here, upon the old business.
I' th' meantime, look tenderly to the two prisoners.
I can tell you they are princes. 15

DAUGHTER 'Tis pity they are in prison.
I do think they have patience to make any adversity ashamed.

JAILER I heard them reported in the battle to be the only doers.

DAUGHTER Nay, most likely, for they are noble suff'rers.
It seems to me they have no more sense 20
of their captivity than I of ruling Athens.

WOOER I never saw 'em.

JAILER The Duke himself came privately in the night,
and so did they.

Enter Palamon and Arcite, in shackles.

Look, yonder they are; that's Arcite looks out. 25

DAUGHTER No, sir, no, that's Palamon. Arcite is the

lower of the twain; you may perceive a part of him.

JAILER Go to, leave your pointing; they would not make us their object. Out of their sight. 30

DAUGHTER It is a holiday to look on them. Lord, the diff'rence of men!

Jailer, Daughter, and Wooer exit.

Scene 2

Palamon and Arcite remain, above.

PALAMON
How do you, noble cousin?

ARCITE How do you, sir?

PALAMON
Why, strong enough to laugh at misery
And bear the chance of war; yet we are prisoners
I fear forever, cousin. 5

ARCITE I believe it,
And to that destiny have patiently
Laid up my hour to come.

PALAMON O, cousin Arcite,
Where is Thebes now? Where is our noble country? 10
Where are our friends and kindreds? Never more
Must we behold those comforts, never see
The hardy youths strive for the games of honor,
Hung with the painted favors of their ladies,
Like tall ships under sail; O, never 15
Shall we two exercise, like twins of honor,
Our arms again, and feel our fiery horses
Like proud seas under us.

ARCITE No, Palamon,
Those hopes are prisoners with us. Here we are 20
And here the graces of our youths must wither
Like a too-timely spring. Here age must find us
And—which is heaviest, Palamon—unmarried.
The sweet embraces of a loving wife,

Loaden with kisses, armed with thousand Cupids, 25
Shall never clasp our necks;
The fair-eyed maids shall weep our banishments
And in their songs curse ever-blinded Fortune
Till she for shame see what a wrong she has done
To youth and nature. This is all our world. 30
We shall know nothing here but one another,
Hear nothing but the clock that tells our woes.

PALAMON
'Tis too true, Arcite. We shall die,
Which is the curse of honor, lastly,
Children of grief and ignorance. 35

ARCITE Yet, cousin,
Even from the bottom of these miseries,
I see two comforts rising, two mere blessings,
If the gods please: to hold here a brave patience,
And the enjoying of our griefs together. 40
Whilst Palamon is with me, let me perish
If I think this our prison!

PALAMON Certainly
'Tis a main goodness, cousin, that our fortunes
Were twined together. 'Tis most true, two souls 45
Put in two noble bodies, let 'em suffer
The gall of hazard, so they grow together,
Will never sink.

ARCITE
Shall we make worthy uses of this place
That all men hate so much? 50

PALAMON How, gentle cousin?

ARCITE
Let's think this prison holy sanctuary
To keep us from corruption of worse men.
We are young and yet desire the ways of honor
We are an endless mine to one another; 55
We are one another's wife, ever begetting
New births of love; we are father, friends, acquaintance;
We are, in one another, families;
I am your heir, and you are mine. This place
Is our inheritance; no hard oppressor 60
Dare take this from us; here with a little patience

We shall live long and loving. No surfeits seek us;
The hand of war hurts none here, nor the seas
Swallow their youth.

PALAMON You have made me— 65
I thank you, cousin Arcite—almost wanton
With my captivity. I find the court here,
I am sure, a more content; and all those pleasures
That woo the wills of men to vanity
I see through now, and am sufficient 70
What had we been, old in the court of Creon,
Where sin is justice, lust and ignorance
The virtues of the great ones? Cousin Arcite,
We had died as they do, ill old men, unwept,
And had their epitaphs, the people's curses. 75
Shall I say more?

ARCITE I would hear you still.

PALAMON You shall.
Is there record of any two that loved
Better than we do, Arcite? 80

ARCITE Sure there cannot.

PALAMON
I do not think it possible our friendship
Should ever leave us.

ARCITE Till our deaths it cannot.

Enter Emilia and her Woman, below.

And after death our spirits shall be led 85

To those that love eternally. *Palamon catches sight of Emilia.*
Speak on, sir.

EMILIA*, to her Woman*
This garden has a world of pleasures in 't.
What flower is this?

WOMAN 'Tis called narcissus[7], madam. 90

EMILIA
That was a fair boy certain, but a fool

[7] Reference to the Greek myth of Narcissus

To love himself. Were there not maids enough?

ARCITE, *to Palamon, who is stunned by the sight of Emilia*
Pray, forward.

PALAMON Yes.

EMILIA, *to Woman* Or were they all hard-hearted? 95

WOMAN They could not be to one so fair.

EMILIA Thou wouldst not.

WOMAN I think I should not, madam.

EMILIA That's a good wench.
But take heed to your kindness, though. 100

WOMAN Why, madam?

EMILIA Men are mad things.

ARCITE, *to Palamon*
Cousin, cousin! How do you, sir? Why, Palamon!

PALAMON
Never till now I was in prison, Arcite.

ARCITE
Why, what's the matter, man? 105

PALAMON Behold, and wonder!
By heaven, she is a goddess.

ARCITE, *seeing Emilia* Ha!

PALAMON Do reverence.
She is a goddess, Arcite. 110

EMILIA, *to Woman* Of all flowers
Methinks a rose is best.

WOMAN Why, gentle madam?

EMILIA
It is the very emblem of a maid.

For when the west wind courts her gently, 115
How modestly she blows and paints the sun
With her chaste blushes! When the north comes near her,
Rude and impatient, then, like chastity,
She locks her beauties in her bud again,
And leaves him to base briers. 120

WOMAN Yet, good madam,
Sometimes her modesty will blow so far
She falls for ’t.

EMILIA Thou art wanton!

ARCITE, *to Palamon*
She is wondrous fair. 125

PALAMON She is all the beauty extant.

EMILIA, *to Woman*
The sun grows high. Let’s walk in.
I am wondrous merry-hearted. I could laugh now.

Emilia and Woman exit.

PALAMON
What think you of this beauty?

ARCITE ’Tis a rare one. 130

PALAMON
Is ’t but a rare one?

ARCITE Yes, a matchless beauty.

PALAMON
Might not a man well lose himself and love her?

ARCITE
Beshrew mine eyes for ’t! Now I feel my shackles.

PALAMON
You love her, then? 135

ARCITE Who would not?

PALAMON And desire her?

ARCITE Before my liberty.

PALAMON I saw her first.

ARCITE That's nothing. 140

PALAMON But it shall be.

ARCITE I saw her, too.

PALAMON Yes, but you must not love her.

ARCITE Who shall deny me?

PALAMON
I, that first saw her; If thou lov'st her, 145
Or entertain'st a hope to blast my wishes,
Thou art a traitor, Arcite, and a fellow
False as thy title to her. Friendship, blood,
And all the ties between us I disclaim
If thou once think upon her. 150

ARCITE Yes, I love her,
I love her with my soul.
If that will lose you, farewell, Palamon.

PALAMON Have I called thee friend?

ARCITE
Yes, and have found me so. Why are you moved thus? 155
Let me deal coldly with you: am not I
Part of your blood, part of your soul? You have
told me
That I was Palamon and you were Arcite.

PALAMON
Yes. 160

ARCITE Why then would you deal so cunningly,
So strangely, so unlike a noble kinsman,
To love alone? Speak truly, do you think me
Unworthy of her sight?

PALAMON No, but unjust 165
If thou pursue that sight.

ARCITE You are mad. Fie, sir!
You play the child extremely. I will love her;
I must, I ought

PALAMON O, that now, that now, 170
Thy false self and thy friend had but this fortune
To be one hour at liberty, and grasp
Our good swords in our hands, I would quickly teach thee
What 'twere to filch affection from another.
Put but thy head out of this window more 175
And, as I have a soul, I'll nail thy life to 't.

ARCITE
Put my head out? I'll throw my body out
And leap the garden when I see her next,
And pitch between her arms to anger thee.
Enter Jailer, above.

PALAMON
No more; the keeper's coming. I shall live 180
To knock thy brains out with my shackles.

ARCITE Do!

JAILER By your leave, gentlemen.

PALAMON Now, honest keeper?

JAILER
Lord Arcite, you must presently to th' Duke; 185
The cause I know not yet.

ARCITE I am ready, keeper.

JAILER
Prince Palamon, I must awhile bereave you
Of your fair cousin's company. *Arcite and Jailer exit.*

PALAMON Why is he sent for? 190
It may be he shall marry her; he's goodly,
And like enough the Duke hath taken notice
Both of his blood and body. If that
Get him a wife so noble and so fair,
Let honest men ne'er love again. Once more 195
I would but see this fair one.
How I would spread and fling my wanton arms

In at her window; I would bring her fruit
Fit for the gods to feed on.

Enter Jailer, above.

And then I am sure she would love me.—How now, keeper, 200
Where's Arcite?

JAILER Banished. Prince Pirithous
Obtained his liberty, but never more
Upon his oath and life must he set foot
Upon this kingdom. 205

PALAMON He's a blessèd man.
He shall see Thebes again. Arcite shall have a fortune,
If he dare make himself a worthy lover,
Yet in the field to strike a battle for her,
And, if he lose her then, he's a cold coward. 210
Were I at liberty, I would do things
Of such a virtuous greatness for this lady.

JAILER My lord, for you
I have this charge to—

PALAMON To discharge my life? 215

JAILER
No, but from this place to remove your Lordship;
The windows are too open.

PALAMON Prithee, kill me.
I will not go.

JAILER
Indeed you must, my lord. 220

PALAMON May I see the garden?

JAILER
No.

PALAMON Then I am resolved, I will not go.
Must I go?

JAILER
There is no remedy. 225

PALAMON Farewell, kind window.
May rude wind never hurt thee. O, my lady,
If ever thou hast felt what sorrow was,
Dream how I suffer.—Come; now bury me.

Palamon and Jailer exit.

Scene 3

Enter Arcite.

ARCITE
Banished the kingdom? 'Tis a benefit,
A mercy I must thank 'em for; but banished
The free enjoying of that face I die for? Palamon,
Thou hast the start now; thou shalt stay and see
Her bright eyes break each morning 'gainst thy window 5
Good gods, what happiness has Palamon!
If I go, he has her.
I am resolved another shape shall make me
Or end my fortunes.

Enter Country people, and one with a garland before them.

Arcite steps aside.

FIRST COUNTRYMAN My masters, I'll be there, that's certain. 10

SECOND COUNTRYMAN And I'll be there.

THIRD COUNTRYMAN And I.

FOURTH COUNTRYMAN Why, then, have with you, boys.
'Tis but a chiding. Let the plough play today.

THIRD COUNTRYMAN Do we all hold against the Maying? 15

FIRST COUNTRYMAN Hold? What should ail us?

THIRD COUNTRYMAN Arcas will be there.

SECOND COUNTRYMAN Will the
dainty domine[8], the Schoolmaster, keep touch, do
you think? For he does all, you know. 20

[8] Schoolmaster

THIRD COUNTRYMAN He'll eat a hornbook[9] ere he fail.

FOURTH COUNTRYMAN Shall we be lusty[10]?

SECOND COUNTRYMAN All the boys in Athens blow wind
i' th' breech on 's.

THIRD COUNTRYMAN We'll see the sports, then every
man to 's tackle. And, sweet companions, let's rehearse,
before the ladies see us.

FOURTH COUNTRYMAN Content. The sports once ended,
we'll perform. Away, boys, and hold.

Arcite comes forward.

ARCITE By your leaves, honest friends: pray you, whither go you?

FOURTH COUNTRYMAN Whither?
Why, what a question's that?

ARCITE Yes, 'tis a question
To me that know not.

THIRD COUNTRYMAN To the games, my friend.

SECOND COUNTRYMAN Where were you bred, you know it not?

ARCITE Not far, sir.

FOURTH COUNTRYMAN Well, sir,
Take your own time.—Come, boys.

FIRST COUNTRYMAN, *aside to the others* My mind misgives
Me. Mark how his body's made for 't.

SECOND COUNTRYMAN, *aside to the others* Hang him,
plum porridge! He wrestle? He roast eggs! Come,
let's be gone, lads. *The four exit.*

ARCITE
This is an offered opportunity
I durst not wish for. I'll venture,
And in some poor disguise be there. Who knows
Whether happiness prefer me to a place
Where I may ever dwell in sight of her?

---

[9] A flat piece of horn with the alphabet and other basic information inscribed on it, for beginning pupils to use.
[10] Lively, jolly (a rhetorical question)

Arcite exits.

Scene 4

Enter Jailer's Daughter, alone.

DAUGHTER

Why should I love this gentleman? 'Tis odds
He never will affect me. I am base,
My father the mean keeper of his prison,
And he a prince. To marry him is hopeless;
To be his wench is witless. Out upon 't! 5
What pushes are we wenches driven to
When fifteen once has found us! First, I saw him;
I, seeing, thought he was a goodly man;
He has as much to please a woman in him,
If he please to bestow it so, as ever 10
These eyes yet looked on. Next, I pitied him,
And so would any young wench, o' my conscience.
Then I loved him,
Extremely loved him, infinitely loved him!
And yet he had a cousin, fair as he too. 15
But in my heart was Palamon, and there,
Lord, what a coil he keeps! To hear him
Sing in an evening, what a heaven it is!
And yet his songs are sad ones. Fairer spoken
Was never gentleman. He grieves much— 20
And me as much to see his misery.
What should I do to make him know I love him?
For I would fain enjoy him. Say I ventured
To set him free? What says the law then?
Thus much for law or kindred! I will do it, 25
And this night, or tomorrow, he shall love me.

She exits.

Scene 5

This short flourish of cornets and shouts within.
Enter Theseus, Hippolyta, Pirithous, Emilia, Arcite
in disguise, with a garland, Attendants, and others.

THESEUS, *to Arcite*

You have done worthily.
You run the best and wrestle
That these times can allow.

ARCITE I am proud to please you.

THESEUS What country bred you?

ARCITE This; but far off, prince.

THESEUS Are you a gentleman?

ARCITE My father said so,

THESEUS Are you his heir?

ARCITE His youngest, sir.

THESEUS Your father,
Sure, is a happy sire, then. What proves you?

ARCITE
A little of all noble qualities.
I dare not praise
My feat in horsemanship, yet they that knew me
Would say it was my best piece. Last, and greatest,
I would be thought a soldier.

THESEUS You are perfect.

PIRITHOUS Upon my soul, a proper man.

EMILIA He is so.

PIRITHOUS*, to Hippolyta*
How do you like him, lady?

HIPPOLYTA I admire him.

EMILIA
His mother was a wondrous handsome woman;
His face, methinks, goes that way.

HIPPOLYTA But his body
And fiery mind illustrate a brave father.

PIRITHOUS
Mark how his virtue, like a hidden sun,
Breaks through his baser garments.

HIPPOLYTA He's well got, sure.

THESEUS, *to Arcite*
What made you seek this place, sir?

ARCITE Noble Theseus,
To purchase name and do my ablest service
For only in thy court, of all the world,
Dwells fair-eyed Honor.

PIRITHOUS All his words are worthy.

THESEUS
Sir, we are much indebted to your travel,
Nor shall you lose your wish.—Pirithous,
Dispose of this fair gentleman.

PIRITHOUS Thanks, Theseus.—
Whate'er you are, you're mine, and I shall give you
To a most noble service: to this lady,
He brings Arcite to Emilia.
You have honored her fair birthday with your virtues,
And, as your due, you're hers. Kiss her fair hand, sir.

ARCITE
Sir, you're a noble giver.—Dearest beauty,
Thus let me seal my vowed faith.
He kisses her hand.
When your servant,
Your most unworthy creature, but offends you,
Command him die, he shall.

EMILIA That were too cruel.

PIRITHOUS, *to Arcite*
I'll see you furnished

THESEUS, *to Hippolyta* Sweet, you must be ready,—
And you, Emilia,—and you, friend,—and all,
Tomorrow by the sun, to do observance
To flowery May in Dian's wood.—Wait well, sir,
Upon your mistress.—Emily, I hope
He shall not go afoot.

EMILIA That were a shame, sir,
While I have horses.—Take your choice, and what

You want at any time, let me but know it.
If you serve faithfully, I dare assure you 60
You'll find a loving mistress.

Flourish. They all exit.

Scene 6

Enter Jailer's Daughter alone.

DAUGHTER

Let all the dukes and all the devils roar!
He is at liberty. I have ventured for him,
And out I have brought him; to a little wood
A mile hence I have sent him, where
He shall keep close 5
Till I provide him files and food, for yet
His iron bracelets are not off.
I love him beyond love and beyond reason
Or wit or safety. I have made him know it;
I care not, I am desperate.That way he takes 10
I purpose is my way too. Sure he cannot
Be so unmanly as to leave me here.
And yet he has not thanked me
For what I have done; no, not so much as kissed me,
And that, methinks, is not so well. I'll presently 15
Provide him necessaries and pack my clothes up,
And where there is a path of ground I'll venture,
So he be with me. Within this hour the hubbub
Will be all o'er the prison. I am then
Kissing the man they look for. Farewell, father! 20

She exits.

ACT 3

Scene 1

Cornets in sundry places. Noise and hallowing
as people a-Maying. Enter Arcite alone.

ARCITE
This is a solemn rite
They owe bloomed May, O Queen Emilia,
Fresher than May, Thrice blessèd chance
To drop on such a mistress, expectation
Most guiltless on ’t. Tell me, O Lady Fortune, 5
Next after Emily my sovereign, how far
I may be proud. She takes strong note of me,
Hath made me near her; and this beauteous morn,
presents me with a brace of horses; Alas, alas,
Poor cousin Palamon, poor prisoner, thou 10
So little dream’st upon my fortune that
Thou think’st thyself the happier thing, to be
So near Emilia; me thou deem’st at Thebes,
And therein wretched, although free. But if
Thou knew’st my mistress breathed on me, and that 15
I eared her language, lived in her eye—O coz,
What passion would enclose thee!

Enter Palamon as out of a bush, with his shackles;
he bends his fist at Arcite.

PALAMON Traitor kinsman,
Thou shouldst perceive my passion if these signs
Of prisonment were off me, and this hand 20
But owner of a sword. Call’st thou her thine?
I’ll prove it in my shackles, that thou liest, and art
A very thief in love. Had I a sword,
And these house clogs away—

ARCITE Dear cousin Palamon— 25

PALAMON
Cozener Arcite, give me language such
As thou hast showed me feat.

ARCITE Honor and honesty
I cherish and depend on, howsoe’er
You skip them in me, and with them, fair coz, 30

I'll maintain my proceedings. Pray be pleased
To show in generous terms your griefs, since that
Your question's with your equal, who professes
To clear his own way with the mind and sword
Of a true gentleman. 35

PALAMON That thou durst, Arcite!

ARCITE
My coz, my coz, you have been well advertised
How much I dare; you've seen me use my sword
Against th' advice of fear.

PALAMON Sir, you were called 40
A good knight and a bold. But the whole week's not
Fair If any day it rain. Come before me then,
A good sword in thy hand, and do but say
That Emily is thine, I will forgive
The trespass thou hast done me—yea, my life, 45
If then thou carry 't.

ARCITE Be content.
These impediments
Will I file off. You shall have garments and
Perfumes to kill the smell o' th' prison. After, 50
there shall be at your choice
Both sword and armor.

PALAMON
I do embrace you and your offer; for
Your offer do 't I only. Sir, your person
Without hypocrisy I may not wish 55
More than my sword's edge on 't.

Wind horns off; sound cornets.

ARCITE Give me your hand; farewell.
I'll bring you every needful thing. I pray you,
Take comfort and be strong.

PALAMON Pray hold your promise, 60
And do the deed with a bent brow. Most certain
You love me not; be rough with me, and pour
This oil out of your language.

ARCITE *Wind horns.*
Hark, sir, they call

The scattered to the banquet; you must guess 65
I have an office there.

PALAMON
You are going now to gaze upon my mistress,
For note you, mine she is—

ARCITE Nay then,—

PALAMON Nay, pray you, 70
You talk of feeding me to breed me strength.
You are going now to look upon a sun
That strengthens what it looks on; there
You have a vantage o'er me, but enjoy 't till
I may enforce my remedy. Farewell. 75
They exit.

Scene 2

Enter Jailer's Daughter, alone.

DAUGHTER
He has mistook the brake I meant, is gone
After his fancy. 'Tis now well-nigh morning.
No matter; would it were perpetual night,
And darkness lord o' th' world. Hark, 'tis a wolf!
In me hath grief slain fear, and but for one thing, 5
I care for nothing, and that's Palamon.
I reck not if the wolves would jaw me, so
He had this file. What if I hallowed for him?
I cannot hallow. How stand I then?
My father's to be hanged for his escape; 10
Myself to beg, if I prized life so much
As to deny my act, but that I would not,
Should I try death by dozens. I am moped;
Food took I none these two days;
Sipped some water. I have not closed mine eyes 15
So, which way now?
The best way is the next way to a grave;
The moon is down. All offices are done
Save what I fail in. But the point is this—
An end, and that is all. 20
She exits.

Scene 3

Enter Arcite with meat, wine, and files.

ARCITE
I should be near the place.—Ho! Cousin Palamon!

PALAMON, *within*
Arcite?

ARCITE The same. I have brought you food and files.
Come forth and fear not; here's no Theseus.

Enter Palamon.

PALAMON
Nor none so honest, Arcite. 5

ARCITE That's no matter.
We'll argue that hereafter. Here, sir, drink—
I know you are faint—then I'll talk further with you.

PALAMON
Arcite, thou mightst now poison me.

ARCITE I might; 10
But I must fear you first. Sit down and, good now,
No more of these vain parleys. To your health.

He drinks.

PALAMON Do!

ARCITE
Pray sit down, then, and let me entreat you,
No mention of this woman; 15

PALAMON Well, sir, I'll pledge you.

He drinks.

ARCITE
Do not you feel it thaw you?

PALAMON Stay, I'll tell you
After a draught or two more.

ARCITE Eat now. 20

PALAMON Yes. *He eats.*

ARCITE

Your hunger needs no sauce, I see.

PALAMON Not much.
But if it did, yours is too tart, sweet cousin.
What is this?

ARCITE Venison.

PALAMON 'Tis a lusty meat.
Give me more wine. Here, Arcite, to the wenches
We have known in our days!

He raises his cup in a toast.

The Lord Steward's daughter!
Do you remember her?

ARCITE After you, coz.

PALAMON
She loved a black-haired man.

ARCITE She did so; well, sir?

PALAMON
And I have heard some call him Arcite, and—

ARCITE
Out with 't, faith.

PALAMON She met him in an arbor.
What did she there, coz? Play o' th' virginals?

ARCITE
Something she did, sir. The Marshal's sister
Had her share, too, as I remember, cousin,

PALAMON Yes.

He lifts his cup and then drinks.

ARCITE
There was a time
When young men went a-hunting, and a wood,
Heigh ho!

PALAMON For Emily, upon my life! Fool,
Away with this strained mirth. I say again
That sigh was breathed for Emily.

ARCITE You are wide.

PALAMON By heaven and Earth,
There's nothing in thee honest. 50

ARCITE Then I'll leave you. You are a beast now.

PALAMON As thou mak'st me, traitor.

ARCITE
I'll come again some two hours hence and bring
That that shall quiet all.

PALAMON A sword and armor. 55

ARCITE
Fear me not. You are now too foul. Farewell.

PALAMON Sirrah—

ARCITE
I'll hear no more.

He exits.

PALAMON If he keep touch, he dies for 't.

He exits.

Scene 4

Enter Jailer's Daughter.

DAUGHTER
I am very cold,—Palamon!
Alas, no; he's in heaven. Where am I now?
Yonder's the sea, and there's a ship. How 't tumbles!
Up with a course or two, and tack about, boys!
Good night, good night; you're gone. I am very hungry. 5
Would I could find a fine frog; he would tell me
News from all parts o' th' world; Now my father,
Twenty to one, is trussed up in a trice
Tomorrow morning. I'll say never a word.
Song

She exits.

Scene 5

Enter a Schoolmaster and six Countrymen,
one dressed as a Bavian.

SCHOOLMASTER Fie, fie, what tediosity and disinsanity
is here among you! Have my rudiments been labored
so long with you, milked unto you, and, by a
figure, even the very plum broth and marrow of
my understanding laid upon you, and do you still 5
cry "Where?" and "How?" and "Wherefore?" *Proh*
deum, medius fidius, you are all dunces! For why,
here stand I; here the Duke comes; there are you,
close in the thicket; the Duke appears; I meet him
and unto him I utter learnèd things, and then cries 10
"Rare!" and I go forward. At length I fling my cap
up—mark there! Then do you
like true lovers, cast yourselves in a body decently,
and sweetly, by a figure, trace and turn, boys.

FIRST COUNTRYMAN And sweetly we will do it, Master 15
Gerald.

SCHOOLMASTER *Quo usque tandem?* Here is a woman
wanting.

Enter Jailer's Daughter.

DAUGHTER, *sings*
The George Alow came from the south,
From the coast of Barbary-a,
And there he met with brave gallants of war,
By one, by two, by three-a.
"Well hailed, well hailed, you jolly gallants,
And whither now are you bound-a?
O, let me have your company
Till I come to the sound-a."
There was three fools, fell out about an owlet—
Sings *The one he said it was an owl,*
The other he said nay,
The third he said it was a hawk,
And her bells were cut away.

THIRD COUNTRYMAN There's a dainty madwoman, master, I warrant
her, she'll do the rarest gambols.

SCHOOLMASTER, *to Jailer's Daughter* And are you mad, 20

good woman?

DAUGHTER I would be sorry else. Give me your hand.

SCHOOLMASTER Why?

DAUGHTER I can tell your fortune. *She looks at his hand.* You are a fool. Friend, you must eat no white bread; if you do, your teeth will bleed extremely. Shall we dance, ho? I know you, you're a tinker.

SCHOOLMASTER *Dii boni!* A tinker, damsel?

DAUGHTER Or a conjurer.

SCHOOLMASTER Go, take her, and fluently persuade her to a peace. Strike up, and lead her in.

SECOND COUNTRYMAN Come, lass, let's trip it.

DAUGHTER I'll lead.

THIRD COUNTRYMAN Do, do!

SCHOOLMASTER Persuasively, and cunningly.

Wind horns.

Away, boys! I hear the horns. Give me some meditation, and mark your cue.

All but Schoolmaster exit.

Pallas[11], inspire me!

Enter Theseus, Pirithous, Hippolyta, Emilia, and train.

THESEUS This way the stag took.

SCHOOLMASTER Stay, and edify!

THESEUS What have we here?

PIRITHOUS Some country sport, upon my life, sir.

THESEUS, *to Schoolmaster* Well, sir, go forward. We will "edify."

Chairs and stools brought out. Theseus, Hippolyta, and Emilia sit.

SCHOOLMASTER
Thou doughty duke, all hail!—All hail, sweet ladies!

[11] Greek Titan, the Titan god of warcraft and of the springtime campaign season

THESEUS, *aside* This is a cold beginning. 45

SCHOOLMASTER
If you but favor, our country pastime made is.
We are a few of those collected here
That ruder tongues distinguish "villager."
And to say verity, and not to fable,
We are a merry rout, or else a rabble, 50
Or company, or by a figure, chorus,
That 'fore thy dignity will dance a morris.
Say "ay," and all shall presently advance.

THESEUS
Ay, ay, by any means, dear Domine.

PIRITHOUS Produce! 55

SCHOOLMASTER
Come forth and foot it.

Music. Enter the Countrymen, Countrywomen, and Jailer's Daughter; they perform a morris dance.

SCHOOLMASTER
Ladies, if we have been merry
And have pleased ye with a derry,
And a derry and a down,
Say the Schoolmaster's no clown.— 60

THESEUS
How does my sweetheart?

HIPPOLYTA
Never so pleased, sir.

EMILIA 'Twas an excellent dance,

THESEUS
Schoolmaster, I thank you.—One see 'em all
rewarded. *An Attendant gives money.* 65

PIRITHOUS
And here's something to paint your pole withal.
He gives money.

THESEUS Now to our sports again.

SCHOOLMASTER
May the stag thou hunt'st stand long,
And thy dogs be swift and strong;
May they kill him without lets, 70
And the ladies eat his dowsets.

Wind horns within. Theseus, Hippolyta, Emilia, Pirithous, and Train exit.

Come, we are all made. *They exit.*

Scene 6

Enter Palamon from the bush.

PALAMON
About this hour my cousin gave his faith
To visit me again, and with him bring
Two swords and two good armors. If he fail,
He's neither man nor soldier. When he left me,
I did not think a week could have restored 5
My lost strength to me, I was grown so low
And crestfall'n with my wants. I thank thee, Arcite,
Thou art yet a fair foe, and I feel myself,
With this refreshing, able once again
To outdure danger. This blest morning 10
Shall be the last; and that sword he refuses,
If it but hold, I kill him with. 'Tis justice.
So, love and fortune for me!

Enter Arcite with armors and swords.

O, good morrow.

ARCITE
Good morrow, noble kinsman. 15

PALAMON I have put you
To too much pains, sir.

ARCITE That too much, fair cousin,
Is but a debt to honor and my duty.

PALAMON
Would you were so in all, sir; I could wish you 20
As kind a kinsman as you force me find
A beneficial foe, that my embraces

Might thank you, not my blows.

ARCITE I shall think either,
Well done, a noble recompense. 25

PALAMON Then I shall quit you.

ARCITE
Will ’t please you arm, sir?
Your person I am friends with,
And I could wish I had not said I loved her,
Though I had died. But loving such a lady, 30
And justifying my love, I must not fly from ’t.

PALAMON
Arcite, thou art so brave an enemy
That no man but thy cousin’s fit to kill thee.
Choose your arms.

ARCITE Choose you, sir. 35

PALAMON *He chooses armor.*
This I’ll take.

ARCITE *taking the other* That’s mine, then.
I’ll arm you first.

PALAMON Do. *Arcite begins arming him.*
Pray thee tell me, cousin, 40
Where got’st thou this good armor?

ARCITE ’Tis the Duke’s,
And to say true, I stole it. Do I pinch you?

PALAMON No.

ARCITE
Is ’t not too heavy? 45

PALAMON I have worn a lighter,
But I shall make it serve.

ARCITE I’ll buckle ’t close.

PALAMON
By any means.

Good cousin, thrust the buckle 50
Through far enough.

ARCITE I warrant you.

PALAMON My casque now.

ARCITE
Will you fight bare-armed?

PALAMON We shall be the nimbler. 55

ARCITE
But use your gauntlets though. Those are o' th' least.
Prithee take mine, good cousin.

PALAMON Thank you, Arcite.
How do I look? Am I fall'n much away?

ARCITE
Faith, very little; love has used you kindly. 60

PALAMON
I'll warrant thee, I'll strike home.

ARCITE Do, and spare not.
I'll give you cause, sweet cousin.

PALAMON Now to you, sir.

He begins to arm Arcite.

Methinks this armor's very like that, Arcite, 65
Thou wor'st that day the three kings fell, but lighter.

ARCITE
I well remember, you outdid me, cousin.
I never saw such valor.

PALAMON
You are modest, cousin.
Is not this piece too strait? 70

ARCITE No, no, 'tis well.

PALAMON
I would have nothing hurt thee but my sword.
A bruise would be dishonor.

ARCITE Now I am perfect.

PALAMON
Stand off, then. 75

ARCITE Take my sword; I hold it better.

PALAMON
I thank you, no; keep it; your life lies on it.
Here's one. My cause and honor guard me!

ARCITE
And me my love!
They bow several ways, then advance and stand.
Is there aught else to say? 80

PALAMON
This only, and no more:
Fight bravely, cousin. Give me thy noble hand.

ARCITE*, as they shake hands*
Here, Palamon. This hand shall never more
Come near thee with such friendship.

PALAMON I commend thee. 85

ARCITE
If I fall, curse me, and say I was a coward,
For none but such dare die in these just trials.
Once more farewell, my cousin.

PALAMON Farewell, Arcite.
Fight.
Horns within. They stand.

ARCITE
Lo, cousin, lo, our folly has undone us! 90

PALAMON Why?

ARCITE
This is the Duke, a-hunting. Gentle cousin,
If you be seen, you perish instantly
For breaking prison, and I, if you reveal me,
For my contempt. 95

PALAMON No, no, cousin,
I will no more be hidden, nor put off
This great adventure to a second trial.

ARCITE You are not mad?

PALAMON
Or I will make th' advantage of this hour 100
Mine own, and what to come shall threaten me
I fear less than my fortune. Know, weak cousin,
I love Emilia, and in that I'll bury
Thee and all crosses else.

ARCITE Then come what can come, 105
Have at thy life!

PALAMON Look to thine own well, Arcite.

Fight again.

Horns. Enter Theseus, Hippolyta, Emilia, Pirithous and train.

THESEUS
What ignorant and mad malicious traitors
Are you, that 'gainst the tenor of my laws
Are making battle, thus like knights appointed, 110
Without my leave and officers of arms?
By Castor[12], both shall die.

PALAMON Hold thy word, Theseus.
We are certainly both traitors, both despisers
Of thee and of thy goodness. I am Palamon, 115
that broke thy prison. And this is Arcite.
A bolder traitor never trod thy ground,
A falser ne'er seemed friend. This is the man
Against thine own edict, follows thy sister,
That fortunate bright star, the fair Emilia, 120
This treachery, like a most trusty lover,
I called him now to answer.
The true decider of all injuries,
Say "Fight again," and thou shalt see me, Theseus,
Do such a justice thou thyself wilt envy. 125

[12] "By Castor", in Roman comedy, is a milk oath, and some believed only women used it. However, it is a serious oath in this context

Then take my life; I'll woo thee to 't.

PIRITHOUS O heaven,
What more than man is this!

THESEUS I have sworn.

ARCITE We seek not
Thy breath of mercy, Theseus.
Let me say thus much: if in love be treason,
So let me be most traitor, and you please me.
For scorning thy edict, duke, ask that lady
Why she is fair, and why her eyes command me
Stay here to love her; and if she say "traitor,"
I am a villain fit to lie unburied.

PALAMON
Let's die together at one instant, duke;
Only a little let him fall before me,
That I may tell my soul he shall not have her.

THESEUS
I grant your wish, for to say true, your cousin
Has ten times more offended, for I gave him
More mercy than you found, sir, your offenses
Being no more than his.—None here speak for 'em,
For ere the sun set both shall sleep forever.

HIPPOLYTA
Alas, the pity! Now or never, sister,
Speak not to be denied.

EMILIA In my face, dear sister,
I find no anger to 'em, nor no ruin.
The misadventure of their own eyes kill 'em.
Yet that I will be woman and have pity,
My knees shall grow to th' ground but I'll get mercy.

She kneels.

Help me, dear sister; in a deed so virtuous,
The powers of all women will be with us.

Hippolyta kneels.

Most royal brother—

HIPPOLYTA Sir, by our tie of marriage—

EMILIA

By your own spotless honor—

HIPPOLYTA By that faith,
That fair hand, and that honest heart you gave me—

EMILIA
By that you would have pity in another; 160
By your own virtues infinite—

HIPPOLYTA By valor;

THESEUS
These are strange conjurings.

PIRITHOUS Nay, then, I'll in too.

He kneels.

By all our friendship, sir, by all our dangers;

EMILIA
By that you would have trembled to deny 165
A blushing maid—

HIPPOLYTA By your own eyes; by strength,
In which you swore I went beyond all women,

PIRITHOUS
To crown all this: by your most noble soul,
Which cannot want due mercy, I beg first— 170

HIPPOLYTA
Next hear my prayers—

EMILIA Last let me entreat, sir—

PIRITHOUS For mercy.

HIPPOLYTA Mercy.

EMILIA Mercy on these princes. 175

THESEUS
You make my faith reel. (*To Emilia.*) Say I felt
Compassion to 'em both, how would you place it?

They rise from their knees.

EMILIA
Upon their lives, but with their banishments.

THESEUS
If you desire their lives, invent a way
Safer than banishment. Can these two live, 180
And have the agony of love about ’em,
And not kill one another? Be wise, then,
And here forget ’em; it concerns your credit
And my oath equally.

EMILIA O, my noble brother, 185
That oath was rashly made, and in your anger;
Besides, I have another oath ’gainst yours,
Of more authority.

THESEUS What is it, sister?

EMILIA
That you would ne’er deny me anything 190
Fit for my modest suit and your free granting.
I tie you to your word now.
Shall anything that loves me perish for me?
That were a cruel wisdom.
O, Duke Theseus, 195
The goodly mothers that have groaned for these,
And all the longing maids that ever loved,
If your vow stand, shall curse me and my beauty,
Despise my cruelty, and cry woe worth me,
Till I am nothing but the scorn of women. 200
For heaven’s sake, save their lives, and banish ’em.

THESEUS
On what conditions?

EMILIA Swear ’em never more
To make me their contention, or to know me,
To tread upon thy dukedom, and to be, 205
Wherever they shall travel, ever strangers
To one another.

PALAMON I’ll be cut a-pieces
Before I take this oath! Forget I love her?
O, all you gods, despise me then! I must love, and will, 210
And for that love must and dare kill this cousin.

THESEUS Will you, Arcite,
Take these conditions?

ARCITE
No, never, duke. 'Tis worse to me than begging
To take my life so basely; though I think 215
I never shall enjoy her, yet I'll preserve
The honor of affection, and die for her,
Make death a devil!

THESEUS
What may be done? For now I feel compassion.

PIRITHOUS
Let it not fall again, sir. 220

THESEUS Say, Emilia,
If one of them were dead, as one must, are you
Content to take th' other to your husband?
I give consent.—Are you content too, princes?

BOTH
With all our souls. 225

THESEUS He that she refuses
Must die then.

BOTH Any death thou canst invent, duke.

ARCITE
If she refuse me, yet my grave will wed me.

THESEUS, *to Emilia* Make choice, then. 230

EMILIA
I cannot, sir; they are both too excellent.

HIPPOLYTA
What will become of 'em?

THESEUS Thus I ordain it—
you shall both to your country,
And each within this month, appear again in this place, 235
In which I'll plant a pyramid; and whether,
Before us that are here, can force his cousin
By fair and knightly strength to touch the pillar,
He shall enjoy her; the other lose his head.

PALAMON Yes.—Here, Cousin Arcite, 240
I am friends again till that hour. *He offers his hand.*

ARCITE I embrace you.
They shake hands.

THESEUS
Are you content, sister?

EMILIA Yes, I must, sir,
Else both miscarry. 245

THESEUS*, to Palamon and Arcite*
Come, shake hands again, then,
And take heed, as you are gentlemen, this quarrel
Sleep till the hour prefixed, and hold your course.

PALAMON
We dare not fail thee, Theseus.
They shake hands again.

THESEUS
When you return, who wins I'll settle here; 250
Who loses, yet I'll weep upon his bier.
They exit.

ACT 4

Scene 1

Enter Jailer and his Friend, the Doctor.

JAILER
Heard you no more? Was nothing said of me
Concerning the escape of Palamon?
Good sir, remember!

FIRST COUNTRYMAN
Palamon has cleared you
And got your pardon, and discovered how 5
And by whose means he escaped, which was your daughter's,
Whose pardon is procured too; and the prisoner,
Not to be held ungrateful to her goodness,
Has given a sum of money to her marriage—
A large one, I'll assure you. 10

JAILER You are a good man
And ever bring good news.
How was it ended?

SECOND COUNTRYMAN
Why, as it should be: they that ne'er begged
But they prevailed had their suits fairly granted; 15
The prisoners have their lives.
But there be new conditions, which you'll hear of
At better time.

JAILER I hope they are good.

DOCTOR They are honorable; 20
How good they'll prove I know not.

Enter Wooer.

WOOER
Alas, sir, where's your daughter?

JAILER Why do you ask?

WOOER
O, sir, when did you see her?

DOCTOR, *aside* How he looks! 25

JAILER
This morning.

WOOER Was she well? Was she in health?
Sir, when did she sleep?

DOCTOR, *aside* These are strange questions.

JAILER
I do not think she was very well—
I asked her questions, and she answered me
So far from what she was, so childishly,
So sillily, as if she were a fool,
An innocent, and I was very angry.
But what of her, sir?

WOOER Nothing but my pity;
But you must know it, and as good by me
As by another that less loves her.

JAILER Well, sir?

WOOER
No, sir, not well.

SECOND FRIEND Not well?

WOOER
'Tis too true; she is mad.

FIRST FRIEND It cannot be.

WOOER
Believe you'll find it so.

JAILER The gods comfort her!
Either this was her love to Palamon,
Or fear of my miscarrying on his 'scape,
Or both.

WOOER 'Tis likely.

JAILER But why all this haste, sir?

WOOER
I'll tell you quickly. As I late was angling
In the great lake that lies behind the palace,
I heard a voice, a shrill one;
Twas one that sung, and by the smallness of it
A boy or woman. I laid me down 55
And listened to the words she sung, for then,
Through a small glade cut by the fishermen,
I saw it was your daughter.

JAILER Pray go on, sir.

WOOER
She sung much, but no sense; only I heard her 60
Repeat this often: "Palamon is gone,
Is gone to th' wood to gather mulberries;
I'll find him out tomorrow."

FIRST FRIEND Pretty soul!

WOOER
"His shackles will betray him; he'll be taken, 65
And what shall I do then?" Then she talked of you, sir—
That you must lose your head tomorrow morning,
And she must gather flowers to bury you,
And see the house made handsome. Then she sung
Nothing but "Willow, willow, willow," and between 70
Ever was "Palamon, fair Palamon."
And then she wept, and sung again, and sighed,
And with the same breath smiled and kissed her hand.

SECOND FRIEND
Alas, what pity it is!

WOOER I made in to her. 75
She saw me, and straight sought the flood. I saved her
And set her safe to land, when presently
She slipped away. I left her with your brother,
And hither came to tell you.
Enter Jailer's Brother, Jailer's Daughter.
Here they are. 80

DAUGHTER, *sings*
May you never more enjoy the light, etc.
Is not this a fine song?

BROTHER O, a very fine one.

DAUGHTER I can sing twenty more.

BROTHER I think you can.

DAUGHTER Are not you a tailor?

BROTHER Yes.

DAUGHTER Where's my wedding gown?

BROTHER I'll bring it tomorrow.

DAUGHTER Do.
Sings. O fair, O sweet, etc.

BROTHER*, to Jailer* You must e'en take it patiently.

JAILER 'Tis true.

DAUGHTER Good e'en, good men. Pray, did you ever hear of one young Palamon?

JAILER Yes, wench, we know him.

DAUGHTER Is 't not a fine young gentleman?

JAILER 'Tis, love.

BROTHER*, aside to others* By no mean cross her; she is then distempered far worse than now she shows.

DOCTOR*, to Daughter* Yes, he's a fine man.

DAUGHTER O , is he so? You have a sister.

DOCTOR Yes.

DAUGHTER But she shall never have him—tell her so—
All the young maids of our
town are in love with him, but I laugh at 'em and
let 'em all alone. Is 't not a wise course?

DOCTOR This is strange.

DAUGHTER As ever you heard, but say nothing.

DOCTOR No.

DAUGHTER Women come from all parts of the dukedom
to him; I'll warrant you, he had not so few last 110
night as twenty to dispatch. He'll tickle 't up in two
hours, if his hand be in.

JAILER, *aside* She's lost past all cure.

BROTHER Heaven forbid, man!

DAUGHTER, *to Jailer*
You are master of a ship? 115

JAILER Yes.

DAUGHTER Where's your compass?

JAILER Here.

DAUGHTER Set it to th' north. And now direct your
course to th' wood, where Palamon lies longing for 120
me.
Sings.
When Cynthia with her borrowed light, etc.
They exit.

Scene 2

Enter Emilia alone, with two pictures.

EMILIA
I'll choose,
And end their strife. Two such young handsome men
Shall never fall for me;
Looks at one of the pictures.
Good heaven,
What a sweet face has Arcite! What an eye, 5
Of what a fiery sparkle and quick sweetness,
Has this young prince! Here Love himself sits smiling;
A shining constellation.
Looks at the other picture.
Palamon

Is but his foil, to him a mere dull shadow;
He's swart and meager, of an eye as heavy
As if he had lost his mother; a still temper,
No stirring in him, no alacrity;
Of all this sprightly sharpness not a smile.
Yet these that we count errors may become him;
Narcissus was a sad boy but a heavenly.
O, who can find the bent of woman's fancy?
And only beautiful, and these the eyes,
These the bright lamps of beauty, that command
And threaten love. Lie there, Arcite.

She puts aside his picture.

Thou art a changeling to him, I am sotted,
Utterly lost.
For if my brother but even now had asked me
Whether I loved, I had run mad for Arcite.
Now, if my sister, more for Palamon.
Stand both together. What a mere child is Fancy,
That, having two fair gods of equal sweetness,
Cannot distinguish, but must cry for both.

Enter Pirithous.

How now, sir?

PIRITHOUS From the noble duke, your brother,
Madam, I bring you news: the knights are come.

EMILIA
To end the quarrel?

PIRITHOUS Yes.

EMILIA Would I might end first!

Enter Theseus, Hippolyta

THESEUS, Your two contending lovers are returned.
Now, my fair sister,
You must love one of them.

EMILIA I had rather both,
So neither for my sake should fall untimely.

THESEUS
Lady, you shall see men fight now.

HIPPOLYTA I wish it,
But not the cause, my lord.
'Tis pity love should be so tyrannous.—
O, my soft-hearted sister, what think you?
Weep not till they weep blood. Wench, it must be. 45

THESEUS, *to Emilia*
You have steeled 'em with your beauty. (*To Pirithous.*) Honored friend,
To you I give the field; pray order it
Fitting the persons that must use it.

PIRITHOUS Yes, sir. 50

THESEUS
Good friend, be royal.

PIRITHOUS There shall want no bravery.

All but Emilia exit.

EMILIA
Poor wench, go weep, for whosoever wins
Loses a noble cousin for thy sins.

She exits.

Scene 3

Enter Jailer, Wooer, Doctor.

DOCTOR Her distraction is more at some time of the moon than at other some, is it not?

JAILER She is continually in a harmless distemper, dreaming of another world, and a better;
and what broken piece of matter soe'er she's about, 5
the name *Palamon* lards it, that she farces ev'ry business withal, fits it to every question.

Enter Jailer's Daughter.

Look where she comes; you shall perceive her behavior. *They stand aside.*

DAUGHTER
We maids that have our livers perished, 10
cracked to pieces with love, we shall come there,
and do nothing all day long but pick flowers with

Proserpine[13]. Then will I make Palamon a nosegay[14];
then let him mark me then.

DOCTOR Note her a little further.

DAUGHTER Alas, 'tis a sore life
they have i' th' other place—such burning, frying,
boiling, hissing, howling, chatt'ring, cursing—O,
they have shrewd measure, take heed! If one be
mad, or hang or drown themselves, thither they
go, Jupiter bless us.

DOCTOR How her brains coins!

DAUGHTER Lords and courtiers that have got maids
with child, they are in this place. In troth, a very grievous punishment,

DOCTOR How she continues this fancy! 'Tis not an engraffed
madness, but a most thick and profound melancholy.

DAUGHTER To hear there a proud lady and a proud city
wife howl together—I were a beast an I'd call it
good sport.
Sings.
I will be true, my stars, my fate, etc.

Daughter exits.

JAILER What think you of her, sir?

DOCTOR I think she has a perturbed mind, which I
cannot minister to.

JAILER Alas, what then?

DOCTOR Understand you she ever affected any man
ere she beheld Palamon?

JAILER I was once, sir, in great hope she had fixed her
liking on this gentleman.

WOOER I did think so, too, and would account I had a
great penn'orth on 't to give half my state that both
she and I, at this present, stood unfeignedly on the
same terms.

---

[13] Queen of the underworld, carried off by Pluto while gathering flowers.
[14] a small bunch of flowers, typically one that is sweet-scented

DOCTOR Take upon you, young sir, her friend,
the name of Palamon; say you come to eat with
her, and to commune of love. This will catch her
attention, for this her mind beats upon;
Sing to her such green songs of love as she says
Palamon hath sung in prison.
Desire to eat with her, carve her, drink to her, and
still among intermingle your petition of grace and
acceptance into her favor. It is a falsehood she is in,
which is with falsehoods to be combated.
This may bring her to eat,
to sleep, and reduce what's now out of square in
her into their former law and regiment.
Let us put it in execution
and hasten the success, which doubt not will bring
forth comfort.

They exit.

ACT 5

Scene 1

Flourish. Enter Theseus, Pirithous, Hippolyta,
. Three altars set up onstage.

THESEUS
Now let ’em enter and before the gods
Tender their holy prayers.
work in hand will honor
The very powers that love ’em.

PIRITHOUS Sir, they enter. 5

Flourish of cornets. Enter Palamon and Arcite.

THESEUS
You valiant and strong-hearted enemies,
Lay by your anger for an hour and, dove-like,
Before the holy altars of your helpers,
The all-feared gods, bow down your stubborn bodies.
I’ll leave you to your prayers. 10

PIRITHOUS Honor crown the worthiest!

Theseus and his train exit.

PALAMON
The glass is running now that cannot finish
Till one of us expire.

ARCITE I am in labor
To push your name, your ancient love, our kindred 15
Out of my memory.

PALAMON You speak well.
Before I turn, let me embrace thee, cousin.

They embrace.

This I shall never do again.

ARCITE One farewell. 20

PALAMON
Why, let it be so. Farewell, coz.

ARCITE Farewell, sir.

Palamon exits.

True worshippers of Mars, go with me
Before the god of our profession. There
Require of him the hearts of lions and 25
The breath of tigers, yea, the fierceness too,
Yea, the speed also—to go on, I mean;
Else wish we to be snails. You know my prize
Must be dragged out of blood; force and great feat
Must put my garland on, where she sticks, 30
The queen of flowers. Our intercession, then,
Must be to him that makes the camp a cistern
Brimmed with the blood of men. Give me your aid,
And bend your spirits towards him.

He goes to Mars's altar, falls on
His facebefore it, and then kneels.

Give me, great Mars, 35
Some token of thy pleasure.

Here hefalls on his face as formerly, and
there is heard clanging of armor, with a short
thunder, as the burst of a battle, whereupon
they all rise and bow to the altar.

O, great corrector of enormous times,
Shaker of o'er-rank states, I do take
Thy signs auspiciously, and in thy name
To my design march boldly.—Let us go. 40

They exit.

Enter Palamon,
with the former observance.

PALAMON

My stars must glister with new fire, or be
Today extinct. Myargument is love,
Which, if the goddess of it grant, she gives
Victory too. To the goddess Venus
Commend me myproceeding, and implore 45
Her power unto myparty.

Here he goes to Venus's altar, falls on
his faces before it, and then kneel.

Hail, sovereign queen of secrets,
that hast the might
Even with an eye-glance to choke Mars's drum
And turn th' alarm to whispers; What godlike power 50
Hast thou not power upon? Take to thy grace
Me, thy vowed soldier, who do bear thy yoke
As 'twere a wreath of roses, yet is heavier
Than lead itself, stings more than nettles.

O, then, most soft sweet goddess,
Give me the victory of this question, which
Is true love's merit, and bless me with a sign
Of thy great pleasure.

Here music is heard; doves are seen to flutter. They fall again upon their faces, then on their knees.

I give thee thanks
For this fair token, which being laid unto
Mine innocent true heart, arms in assurance
My body to this business.—Let us rise
And bow before the goddess. *They rise and bow.*
Time comes on.

They exit.

Still music of recorders. Enter Emilia in white, her hair about her shoulders, wearing a wheaten wreath; one in white holding up her train, her hair stuck with flowers; one before her carrying a silver hind, in which is conveyed incense and sweet odors, which being set upon the altar of Diana, her maids standing aloof, she sets fire to it. Then they curtsy and kneel.

EMILIA
O sacred, shadowy, cold, and constant queen,
Abandoner of revels, mute contemplative,
Sweet, solitary, thy priest,
Am humbled 'fore thine altar. Look on thy virgin,
And, sacred silver mistress, lend thine ear to my petition,
Seasoned with holy fear. I am bride-habited
But maiden-hearted. A husband I have 'pointed,
But do not know him. Out of two I should
Choose one, and pray for his success, but I
Am guiltless of election. Therefore, most modest queen,
He of the two pretenders that best loves me
And has the truest title in 't, let him
Take off my wheaten garland, or else grant
The file and quality I hold I may
Continue in thy band.

Here the hind vanishes under the altar, and in the place ascends a rose tree, having one rose upon it.

See what our general of ebbs and flows
Out from the bowels of her holy altar
With sacred act advances: but one rose.
If well inspired, this battle shall confound

Both these brave knights,

Here is heard a sudden twang of instruments,
and the rose falls from the tree.

The flower is fall'n. O mistress, 85
Thou here dischargest me. I shall be gathered;
I think so, but I know not thine own will.
Unclasp thy mystery!—I hope she's pleased;
Her signs were gracious.

They curtsy and exit.

Scene 2

Enter Doctor, Jailer, and Wooer in
the habit of Palamon.

DOCTOR
Has this advice I told you done any good upon her?

WOOER
O, very much. The maids that kept her company
Have half-persuaded her that I am Palamon;
Within this half-hour she came smiling to me,
And asked me what I would eat, and when I would 5
kiss her.
I told her "Presently,"

DOCTOR
'Twas well done

WOOER Then she told me she would have me sing.

DOCTOR You did so? 10

WOOER No.

DOCTOR 'Twas very ill done, then.
You should observe her ev'ry way.

WOOER Alas,
I have no voice, sir, to confirm her that way. 15

DOCTOR
That's all one, if you make a noise.
If she entreat again, do anything.

JAILER Ho there, doctor!

DOCTOR
Yes, in the way of cure.

JAILER But first, by your leave,
I' th' way of honesty.

DOCTOR That's but a niceness. Pray bring her in
And let's see how she is.

JAILER I will, and tell her
Her Palamon stays for her. But, doctor,
Methinks you are i' th' wrong still. *Jailer exits.*

DOCTOR Go, go.
You fathers are fine fools.

Enter Jailer, Daughter

She comes; pray humor her.

Wooer and Doctor stand aside.

JAILER*, to Daughter*
Come, your love Palamon stays for you, child,
And has done this long hour, to visit you.

DAUGHTER
I thank him for his gentle patience.
He's a kind gentleman, and I am much bound to him.
Did you ne'er see the horse he gave me?

JAILER Yes.

DAUGHTER How do you like him?

JAILER He's a very fair one.

DAUGHTER You never saw him dance?

JAILER No.

DAUGHTER I have, often.
He dances very finely.

JAILER That's fine indeed.

DOCTOR, *aside* What stuff she utters!

Wooer and Doctor come forward.

JAILER
Make curtsy; here your love comes.

WOOER Pretty soul,
How do you? *Daughter curtsies.*
That's a fine maid; there's a curtsy!

DAUGHTER
Yours to command i' th' way of honesty.— 50
How far is 't now to th' end o' th' world, my masters?

DOCTOR
Why, a day's journey, wench.

DAUGHTER, *to Wooer* Will you go with me?

WOOER
What shall we do there, wench?

DAUGHTER Why, play at 55
stool-ball. What is there else to do?

WOOER I am content,
If we shall keep our wedding there.

DAUGHTER 'Tis true,
For there, I will assure you, we shall find 60
Some blind priest for the purpose, that will venture
To marry us; for here they are nice and foolish.
Besides, my father must be hanged tomorrow,
And that would be a blot i' th' business.
Are not you Palamon? 65

WOOER Do not you know me?

DAUGHTER
Yes, but you care not for me; I have nothing.

WOOER
That's all one; I will have you.

DAUGHTER Will you surely?

WOOER, *taking her hand*

Yes, by this fair hand, will I.

DAUGHTER
Is not this your cousin Arcite? *She indicates Doctor.*

DOCTOR Yes, sweetheart,
And I am glad my cousin Palamon
Has made so fair a choice.

DAUGHTER Do you think he'll have me?

DOCTOR
Yes, without doubt.

DAUGHTER, *to Jailer* Do you think so too?

JAILER Yes.

DAUGHTER
We shall have many children. (*To Doctor.*) Lord,
how you're grown!
My Palamon, I hope, will grow too, finely,
Now he's at liberty. Alas, poor chicken,
He was kept down with hard meat and ill lodging,

JAILER, *aside to Doctor* How do you like her?

DOCTOR
I'll warrant you, within these three or four days
I'll make her right again.
(*To Wooer.*) You must not from her,
But still preserve her in this way.

WOOER I will.

DOCTOR
Let's get her in.

WOOER Come, sweet, we'll go to dinner
And then we'll play at cards.

DAUGHTER And shall we kiss too?

WOOER A hundred times.

DAUGHTER But you shall not hurt me.

WOOER
I will not, sweet.

DAUGHTER If you do, love, I'll cry.

They exit.

Scene 3

Flourish. Enter Theseus, Hippolyta,
Emilia, Pirithous, and some Attendants.

EMILIA
I'll no step further.

PIRITHOUS Will you lose this sight?

EMILIA
I had rather see a wren hawk at a fly
Than this decision; ev'ry blow that falls
Threats a brave life; I will stay here. 5
It is enough my hearing shall be punished
With what shall happen

PIRITHOUS*, to Theseus* Sir, my good lord,
Your sister will no further.

THESEUS O, she must. 10

EMILIA Pardon me.
If I were there, I'd wink.

HIPPOLYTA You must go.

EMILIA
In faith, I will not.

THESEUS Why, the knights must kindle 15
Their valor at your eye. Know, of this war
You are the treasure.

EMILIA Sir, pardon me.
The title of a kingdom may be tried
Out of itself. 20

THESEUS Well, well, then; at your pleasure.

HIPPOLYTA Farewell, sister.
I am like to know your husband ’fore yourself

Theseus, Hippolyta, Pirithous, and others, exit. Emilia remains, comparing again the pictures of Arcite and Palamon.

EMILIA
Arcite is gently visaged, yet his eye
Is like an engine bent, or a sharp weapon
In a soft sheath. Palamon
Has a most menacing aspect; his brow
Is graved, and seems to bury what it frowns on;
Yet sometimes ’tis not so, but alters to
The quality of his thoughts. Long time his eye
Will dwell upon his object. Melancholy
Becomes him nobly; so does Arcite’s mirth;
But Palamon’s sadness is a kind of mirth,
So mingled, as if mirth did make him sad
And sadness merry.

Cornets. Trumpets sound as to a charge.

Hark how yon spurs to spirit do incite
The princes to their proof! If I were by,
I might do hurt, for they would glance their eyes
Towards my seat, and in that motion might
Omit a ward or forfeit an offense
Which craved that very time.

Cornets. A great cry and noise within crying “À Palamon!”

It is much better
I am not there. O, better never born
Than minister to such harm!

Enter Servant.

What is the chance?

SERVANT The cry’s “À Palamon.”

EMILIA Then he has won. ’Twas ever likely.
He looked all grace and success. I prithee run
And tell me how it goes.

Shout and cornets, crying “À Palamon!”

SERVANT Still “Palamon.”

EMILIA
Run and inquire. *Servant exits.*

Addressing Arcite's picture. Poor servant, thou hast lost.
Upon my right side still I wore thy picture,
Palamon's on the left.

Another cry, and shout within, and cornets.

This burst of clamor 55
Is sure th' end o' th' combat.

Enter Servant.

SERVANT
They said that Palamon had Arcite's body
Within an inch o' th' pyramid, that the cry
Was general "À Palamon." But anon,
Th' assistants made a brave redemption, and 60
The two bold titlers at this instant are
Hand to hand at it.

EMILIA Were they metamorphosed
Both into one. *Cornets. Cry within, "Arcite, Arcite."*
More exulting? 65
"Palamon" still?

SERVANT Nay, now the sound is "Arcite."

EMILIA
I prithee lay attention to the cry;
Set both thine ears to th' business.

Cornets. A great shout, and cry "Arcite, victory!"

SERVANT The cry is "Arcite" 70
And "Victory! Hark, Arcite, victory!"
The combat's consummation is proclaimed
By the wind instruments.

EMILIA Half-sights saw
That Arcite was no babe. God's lid, his richness 75
And costliness of spirit looked through him; I did think
Good Palamon would miscarry, yet I knew not
Why I did think so. Our reasons are not prophets
When oft our fancies are. They are coming off.
Alas, poor Palamon! 80

Cornets. Enter Theseus, Hippolyta, Pirithous,
Arcite as victor, and Attendants and others.

THESEUS
Fairest Emily,

The gods by their divine arbitrament
Have given you this knight; he is a good one
As ever struck at head.—Give me your hands.
Receive you her, you him. Be plighted with 85
A love that grows as you decay.

ARCITE Emily,
To buy you I have lost what's dearest to me
Save what is bought, and yet I purchase cheaply,
As I do rate your value. 90

HIPPOLYTA O loved sister,
He speaks now of as brave a knight as e'er
Did spur a noble steed. Surely the gods
Would have him die a bachelor, lest his race
Should show i' th' world too godlike. —Wear the garland 95
With joy that you have won.—For the subdued,
Give them our present justice, since I know
Their lives but pinch 'em. Let it here be done.
The scene's not for our seeing. Go we hence
Right joyful, with some sorrow.—Arm your prize; 100
I know you will not lose her.—Emilia,
I see one eye of yours conceives a tear,
The which it will deliver.

EMILIA Is this winning?
O all you heavenly powers, where is your mercy?

HIPPOLYTA Infinite pity 105
That four such eyes should be so fixed on one
That two must needs be blind for 't.

THESEUS So it is.

Flourish. They exit.

Scene 4

Enter Guard with Palamon and pinioned; Jailer, and Executioner.

PALAMON
There's many a man alive that hath outlived
The love o' th' people. We expire,
And not without men's pity. To live still,
Have their good wishes. My dear kinsmen,
Whose lives for this poor comfort are laid down, 5

You have sold ’em too too cheap.
To Jailer. Ah ha, my friend, my friend,
Your gentle daughter gave me freedom once;
You’ll see ’t done now forever. Pray, how does she?
I heard she was not well; her kind of ill 10
Gave me some sorrow.

JAILER Sir, she’s well restored,
And to be married shortly.

PALAMON By my short life,
I am most glad on ’t. ’Tis the latest thing 15
I shall be glad of; prithee, tell her so.
Commend me to her, and to piece her portion,
Tender her this. *He gives his purse to Jailer.*

JAILER
The gods requite you and make her thankful!

PALAMON
Adieu, and let my life be now as short 20
As my leave-taking.
Lays his head on the block.

A great noise within crying “Run!” “Save!” “Hold!”

Enter in haste a Messenger.

MESSENGER
Hold, hold! O, hold, hold, hold!

Enter Pirithous in haste.

PIRITHOUS
Hold, ho! It is a cursèd haste you made
If you have done so quickly!—Noble Palamon,
The gods will show their glory in a life 25
That thou art yet to lead.

PALAMON How do things fare?

PIRITHOUS
Arise, great sir, and give the tidings ear
That are most dearly sweet and bitter.

PALAMON, *rising* What
Hath waked me from my dream?

PIRITHOUS List then: your cousin,
Mounted upon a steed that Emily
Did first bestow on him–on this horse is Arcite
Trotting the stones of Athens. As he thus went counting
The flinty pavement, dancing, as 'twere, to th' music
His own hooves made darted a spark,
the hot horse, hot as fire,
Took toy at this and fell to what disorder
His power could give his will; on his hind hoofs
On end he stands
That Arcite's legs, being higher than his head,
Seemed with strange art to hang. His victor's wreath
Even then fell off his head, and presently
Backward the jade comes o'er, and his full poise
Becomes the rider's load. Yet is he living
But such a vessel 'tis that floats but for
The surge that next approaches. He much desires
To have some speech with you. Lo, he appears.

Enter Theseus, Hippolyta, Emilia,
and Arcite carried in a chair.

PALAMON
O, miserable end of our alliance!
The gods are mighty, Arcite. If thy heart,
Thy worthy, manly heart, be yet unbroken,
Give me thy last words. I am Palamon,
One that yet loves thee dying.

ARCITE Take Emilia
And with her all the world's joy. Reach thy hand;
Farewell. I have told my last hour. I was false,
Yet never treacherous. Forgive me, cousin.
One kiss from fair Emilia. *She kisses him.*
'Tis done.
Take her. I die.
He dies.

PALAMON Thy brave soul seek Elysium!

EMILIA
I'll close thine eyes, prince. Blessed souls be with thee!
Thou art a right good man, and while I live,
This day I give to tears.

PALAMON And I to honor.

THESEUS
In this place first you fought; e'en very here
I sundered you. Acknowledge to the gods
Our thanks that you are living.
So the deities
Have showed due justice.—Bear this hence.

PALAMON O cousin,
That we should things desire which do cost us
The loss of our desire, that naught could buy
Dear love but loss of dear love.

Arcite's body is carried out.

THESEUS Never Fortune
Did play a subtler game. The conquered triumphs;
The victor has the loss; yet in the passage
The gods have been most equal.—Palamon,
Your kinsman hath confessed the right o' th' lady
Did lie in you, for you first saw her and
Even then proclaimed your fancy. Lead your lady off,
And call your lovers from the stage of death,
Whom I adopt my friends. A day or two
Let us look sadly, and give grace unto
The funeral of Arcite, in whose end
The visages of bridegrooms we'll put on
And smile with Palamon. O you heavenly charmers,
What things you make of us! For what we lack
We laugh, for what we have are sorry, still
Are children in some kind.-Let's go off
And bear us like the time.

Flourish. They exit.